
The Avatar Debate That Needs to End

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The most successful director in the history of movies has done it again. In its third weekend in theaters, [Avatar: Fire and Ash](#)'s box-office take rose to \$1.08 billion, making James Cameron the first director with four movies to earn \$1 billion or more. That's not just four total but four in a row, beginning with 1997's [Titanic](#), which means there are now people in their 30s who weren't born the last time one of Cameron's movies failed to make 10 figures.

Film for film, that's a level of consistent box-office dominance no other auteur can match: not Steven Spielberg, not Christopher Nolan, not even the Russo brothers, the only directors other than Cameron to have multiple movies in the all-time box-office Top 10, with their two [Avengers](#) movies. And yet, even as someone who spends the last six weeks of the year fielding queries about what's worth catching up with, I can't remember a single person asking me about the third entry in a franchise that has sold hundreds of millions of tickets worldwide, defying widespread skepticism to draw audiences back again and again. You can't log onto the internet without hitting an [elaborate fan theory](#) about the ending of [Stranger Things](#), but apart from some sporadic online lust for Oona Chaplin's warrior chieftain, you'd be hard-pressed to know that *Fire and Ash* even exists, let alone that it's the biggest movie in the world.

The problem with the “no cultural impact” argument around the *Avatar* series is that it is almost entirely vibes-based.

For nearly as long as the *Avatar* movies have been atop the box-office charts, people have been debating their lack of staying power. Not even five years after *Avatar* became the highest-grossing movie of all time, Forbes argued that the movie had left “[no real pop culture footprint](#),” and in 2022, the New York Times set out to investigate “[The Mystery of the Vanishing Blockbuster](#),” only a few weeks before [The Way of Water](#) began a box-office run that would take it to third place on the all-time list. The second movie's \$2.3 billion gross, accrued 13 years after the first's \$2.8 billion, would seem to have provided a definitive answer to the question “Does anyone still care about *Avatar*?” And yet even after the third movie debuted with an opening weekend of nearly \$350 million, the internet was still swarming with people [hot to make the case](#) that the movies have, to use their preferred phrase, “no cultural impact,” as an (I thought) innocuous Bluesky post dropped over Christmas vacation quickly made clear.

The argument, if I can reproduce it fairly, goes something like this: Where are the quotes? Where are the memes? When was the last time you heard someone drop an *Avatar* reference, or one of its concepts worked its way into everyday speech? Does anyone remember what happened in the last movie, or even the names of its characters? Everyone knows Luke Skywalker, Iron Man, what it means to say someone acts like a Slytherin. And yet the average person on the street couldn't tell you one thing about these supposedly globe-conquering movies. They have, to paraphrase a movie whose cultural reach far outstrips its box-office rank, failed to make fetch happen.

The problem with the “no cultural impact” argument around the *Avatar* series is that it is almost entirely vibes-based. Scott Mendelson, the author of the 2014 Forbes article, didn't conduct a poll before asserting that “most general moviegoers couldn't tell you the name of a single character from the film, nor could they name any of the actors who appeared in it”—he just presented it as fact. And while that might square with his experience, or even with mine, I can't help thinking of the legendary film critic Pauline Kael's observation that she only knew one person who [voted to reelect](#)

[Richard Nixon](#) in 1972. The quote often gets recirculated as evidence of the coastal bubble which mainstream cultural critics inhabit, but rarely with the knowledge that that's how Kael meant it in the first place. She didn't mean that no one voted for Nixon, but that those who did lay outside the "rather special world" in which she lived.

I don't know anyone who's obsessed with the *Avatar* series, at least outside of colleagues who are professionally required to pay attention to them. But I also don't know anyone in mainland China, where *Fire and Ash* closed out the year dominating the box office, earning more than \$137 million to date. What little quantitative inquiry has been done into *Avatar*'s cultural impact—like the [Ankler's analysis](#) of how Google searches for the franchise have declined over time, or how the number of fan wiki pages devoted to its lore fail to measure up—focuses exclusively on English-language culture, or at the very least doesn't provide any specifics about the series' profile in other countries.

What we do know, beyond a shadow of a doubt, is that people keep buying tickets to *Avatar* movies. And while interest may have flagged somewhat—*Fire and Ash* took 18 days to cross the \$1 billion mark, one day longer than the original movie and four days longer than *The Way of Water*—even the most conservative projections have the new movie clearing \$1.5 billion worldwide, which would make it the 16th-highest grosser of all time. And that's the worst-case scenario, one that doesn't factor in Cameron's decades-long history of inspiring repeat viewings and proving his doubters wrong. It's even more impressive when you consider that the two sequels' ticket sales come against the backdrop of what is looking more and more like a permanent post-COVID decline in the audience for theatrical moviegoing. Even when you adjust for the elevated price of seeing an *Avatar* movie in Cameron's preferred large-format 3D and look at [raw admissions](#), the first *Avatar* is estimated to rank slightly below the original *Star Wars* and a bit above *Gone With the Wind*.

To avoid having to stand outside the nearest multiplex and quiz exiting moviegoers about where you put the apostrophe in "Lo'ak," I will concede the point that *Avatar*'s impact doesn't resemble that of other movies of its size; a reference to Toruk Makto doesn't have the same cultural currency as a mention of *Wingardium Leviosa*, as evidenced by the fact that I only had to Google how to spell one of them. But it also seems impossible that hundreds of millions of people would pay to see the first movie in 2009, a second 13 years later, and a third three years after that because they felt no connection to the series. *Something* keeps bringing them back.

If *Avatar* feels less ubiquitous than other franchises, it's in substantial part because it simply is. The reason there are nearly 200,000 wiki pages devoted to *Star Wars* and barely more than 2,000 devoted to *Avatar* is because the former's expanded universe encompasses hundreds of hours of movies and TV shows, spinoff novels, and comic books, including those no longer considered part of the official canon, whereas virtually everything you need to know about the *Avatar* universe is contained in the three movies themselves. (There are, technically, a handful of video games and comics, but the movies make few if any reference to their storylines.) Most Hollywood studios are desperate to keep their precious intellectual property in the public eye, terrified that audiences will lose their connection to the world and not feel compelled to keep up with each new installment. But Cameron isn't afraid of giving them a little bit of a break, because he's confident he can lure back the audience anew each time, and he'd rather delay a movie for a year or more to ensure every frame is finished to his exacting specifications. He's also, of course, one of the only directors who can simply inform a major movie studio that their billion-dollar investment is going to take a little longer to bear fruit.

It is admittedly odd that the *Avatar* movies have offered up so little in the way of quotable dialogue or meme-worthy moments, especially considering that they're made by the man who gave us "I'll

be back,” “Hasta la vista, baby,” and “I’m the king of the world!” But it also seems unlikely that the writer of *Aliens*, *Titanic*, and the first two *Terminator* movies has simply forgotten how to write punchy action-movie quips—especially since he’s now co-writing with some of the best franchise screenwriters of the 21st century, including the new *Planet of the Apes* series’ Rick Jaffa and Amanda Silver. But he and his writers have embraced a more simplified, broad-stroke approach to character and dialogue, one which puts the movies right on the border between telling stories with universal appeal and simply rehashing familiar tropes, including many copied over from Cameron’s previous films.

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In practical terms, it’s been stunningly effective. The generic storylines and subtext-free dialogue have allowed the *Avatar* films to resonate with a massive global audience, one whose emotions are driven more by the movies’ visual imagery than the details of their plots. And that’s the key to why their appeal is both so enduring and so elusive. If it’s true that many viewers can’t remember the names of Jake Sully and Neytiri, it might be because that’s not who they came to see. It’s a movie-critic cliché that a movie’s location can be a character in its own right, but in the case of Pandora, it’s textually accurate, since the entire planet is linked in a Gaia-like hive mind. When I think back on the *Avatar* movies I’ve seen, what comes to mind is not pithy dialogue or emotional turning points, but images: the ashes of the decimated Hometree drifting softly through the air, the majesty of psychic whales swimming through alien oceans, enormous airships lifted by billowing balloons that shimmer like mother-of-pearl. It’s one reason why, as much as I value the movies and esteem Cameron’s work, I will never see an *Avatar* in anything but theatrical 3D, because any other format would rob the movies of their most, perhaps their only, exceptional qualities. You can watch an *Avatar* movie at home, the same way you can look at a postcard of *Guernica*, but it won’t give you an inkling of its real power.

If the *Avatar* series’ impact starts diminishing the moment the movies leave theaters, that might be because they’re not meant to be seen any other way—and that might not be such a bad thing. One reason that *The Way of Water* did so well is because the 13-year gap between movies actually gave audiences a chance to miss them. (It took Marvel years of diminishing returns to realize even superfans might need the occasional breather.) All but the biggest hits fade with time—when was the

last time you heard someone mention *The Sting*?—and that forgetting is far more natural than the forced drumbeat of awareness that modern franchises impose on their increasingly worn-out audiences. Apart from their box-office haul, the most concrete evidence of *Avatar*'s lasting impact doesn't have anything to do with the movies' story, or even their images: It's the fact that if you went around the back of a major multiplex in December 2009, you could find their 35mm projectors sitting out with the trash. The movie industry had already put its chips on the transition to digital projection, but *Avatar* made the case more powerfully than any shareholder presentation. Its bleeding-edge technology called out for the latest and greatest in theatrical experiences, and Cameron, as is his wont, sweated every imaginable detail, creating [dozens of variations of the film](#) so that it could be optimized for every conceivable theatrical environment.

The result was so stunning that some viewers experienced what came to be known as "[Post-*Avatar* Depression Syndrome](#)," a feeling of acute despair at being forced to leave Pandora's breathtakingly tactile world behind. Even 16 years later, the first *Avatar* still looks better than almost any effects-driven movie made since. If few have tried to copy its success, it might be because they simply lack the ability to follow in its four-toed footsteps.

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